Adil Ahsan

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HARVARD UNIVERSITY

Harvard Kennedy School
79 John F. Kennedy Street
Cambridge, MA 02138

Placement Director: Joseph Aldy — joseph_aldy@hks.harvard.edu
Placement Director: Mark Shepard — mark_shepard@hks.harvard.edu
Administrative Director: Nicole Tateosian — nicole_tateosian@hks.harvard.edu

Education

Harvard Kennedy School, Cambridge, MA — August 2021 – present
PhD in Public Policy (Economics)
Expected Completion: May 2027

Dartmouth College, Hanover, NH — June 2019
B.A. in Economics, Minor in Statistics

Fields

Primary Field: Development Economics
Secondary Field: Political Economy

References

Augustin Bergeron — abergeron@fas.harvard.edu
Asim Ijaz Khwaja (Chair) — khwaja@hks.harvard.edu
Eliana La Ferrara — elaferrara@hks.harvard.edu

Teaching

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA

Ec 10B: Principles of Macroeconomics; for David Laibson and Jason Furman	Spring '24–'26
Ec 10A: Principles of Microeconomics; for David Laibson and Jason Furman	Fall '23, '25
Ec 1010A: Microeconomic Theory; for Maxim Boycko	Fall '24

Dartmouth College, Hanover, NH

Econ 44: Topics in Development Economics; for Eric Edmonds	Winter '19
Econ 49: Topics in International Economics; for Nina Pavcnik	Winter '19

Research Projects

From the Pulpit to the People: Experimental Evidence on the Impact of Friday Sermons
Louis Pasteur Prize for Best PhD Student Paper (AFE, UChicago 2026)
Weiss Fund Distinguished PhD Research Paper Award (NEUDC, Cornell 2026)
Job Market Paper

Religious institutions persuade in large part through their sermons. Yet we know little about how sermons impact behavior, whether their persuasiveness derives from the authority of religious leaders or the religious arguments in messaging, or the dynamics of how content evolves and congregants respond to content in the long run. I explore these questions in the context of the Friday sermon—one of the most widespread forms of religious persuasion in the Muslim world. I randomize 309 mosques in Pakistan to sermons on women's rights, neighbors' rights, or a control condition, with additional variation in whether religious leaders rely on religious or secular arguments. I find sizable impacts of women's rights sermons (0.23 SD) and neighbors' rights sermons (0.19 SD) on men's behavior 2–4 weeks after treatments, with effects extending indirectly to wives who do not hear sermons and yet report more pro-rights beliefs. Sermons are far more persuasive when grounded in religious arguments for women's rights but in secular arguments for neighbors' rights, which I rationalize with a Bayesian framework in which conservative religious priors constrain updating from secular signals. Examining equilibrium dynamics, I document persistence in pro-rights sermon content, consistent with leader learning, on the supply side. On the demand side, I document a 20% decline in congregation size at women's rights mosques that persists 6–12 months later, consistent with congregants avoiding persuasive but costly information. These findings highlight how the demand and supply sides of religious institutions interact to shape individuals' behavior.

Doctor's Orders vs Divine Wisdom

Low trust in secular state institutions can limit the effectiveness of informational interventions among religious populations. Recent work has suggested the potential for religious leaders to be utilized for information dissemination, but research directly comparing the efficacy of religious with secular leaders is lacking. Moreover, what, if any, are the unintended consequences of utilizing religious leaders as frontline agents tasked with achieving state goals? In this project, I explore the educational role of local leaders and compare the ability of local religious and secular leaders to encourage positive health behaviors in the context of a state-sponsored handwashing campaign in Punjab, Pakistan. In collaboration with the Pakistan Ministry of Health, I randomize Pakistani couples to meetings with either their local health worker or religious leader and then evaluate changes in hand hygiene, handwashing behavior, and beliefs about handwashing. Through lab-in-field games, I explore the micro-foundations for separation of Church and State by evaluating whether reliance on religious leaders for information dissemination makes them the preferred choice for information in the future, even on secular topics. In doing so, this work sheds light on the benefits and pitfalls of using religious leaders to achieve policy goals through state-sponsored information campaigns.

The Market for Religious Content: Evidence from Friday Sermons in Pakistan

What drives religious content? In this project, I explore this question from both the demand and supply side in the context of mosques in Punjab, Pakistan. On the demand side, I provide congregants with "content information" (i.e. sermon content of nearby mosques) or "mosque information" (i.e. amenities and congregation characteristics of nearby mosques) and evaluate impacts on mosque choice. On the supply side, I provide religious leaders with "market information" (i.e. congregants' preferences and sermon content of nearby mosques) or "top-down information" (beliefs of senior religious leaders) and look at endogenous changes to sermon content. Results have implications for policymakers seeking to understand the drivers of local hate speech and polarization and ways in which increased information can reduce the influence of controversial leaders.

Why Families Pay: Misperceptions and the Persistence of Dowry
with Abdullah Shahid

Dowry payments routinely amount to several times a household's annual income in many developing contexts, pushing families into debt and inviting marital violence on daughters. Existing work has largely neglected the role of beliefs in helping explain the persistence of dowry, despite how beliefs about what other households privately think of the practice, the religious acceptability of dowry, and what the payment buys a daughter, are crucial to the decision of how much to give and may each be systematically skewed. Working with a sample of households with soon-to-marry daughters in rural Punjab, Pakistan, we document the extent to which such misperceptions exist and whether information correcting beliefs can shift dowry decisions. We document misperceptions by comparing individuals' beliefs to ground truths constructed from surveys of the local population, randomize households to a correction of each of these three beliefs, and evaluate changes in realized dowry payments. Results have implications for the optimal design of anti-dowry policy.

Past Experience

Center for Economic Research in Pakistan (CERP), Lahore, Pakistan — June – August 2022
Research Assistant to Asim Khwaja

Zell/Lurie Real Estate Center, Wharton, Philadelphia, PA — August 2019 – June 2021
Pre-Doctoral Research Assistant to Maisy Wong and Nina Harari

Dartmouth Economics Department, Hanover, NH — March 2017 – June 2019
Research Assistant to Eric Edmonds, Patricia Anderson, and Diego Comin

Edgeworth Economics, Washington, D.C. — June – August 2018
Economic Consulting Intern

Affiliations

Graduate Research Fellow, Harvard Weatherhead Research Cluster on Identity and Conflict	2026–
Graduate Student Affiliate, Harvard Weatherhead Center	2024–
Graduate Student Affiliate, Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science	2024–
PhD Affiliate, Harvard Center for International Development	2023–
Graduate Student Fellow, Center for Economic Research in Pakistan	2023–

Research Grants

$9,000	Weatherhead Center	Market for Religious Content	2026
$47,186	The Weiss Fund	Doctor's Orders vs Divine Wisdom	2025
$2,000	South Asia Institute	Market for Religious Content	2025
$1,000	IQSS	Doctor's Orders vs Divine Wisdom	2025
$12,967	The Weiss Fund	Doctor's Orders vs Divine Wisdom	2024
$3,910	Weatherhead Center	Doctor's Orders vs Divine Wisdom	2024
$2,000	IQSS	Doctor's Orders vs Divine Wisdom	2024
$2,000	Harvard SAI	Doctor's Orders vs Divine Wisdom	2024
$74,162	IGC	From the Pulpit to the People	2024
$9,846	J-PAL GI	From the Pulpit to the People	2023

Fellowships & Awards

Weiss Fund Distinguished PhD Research Paper Award, NEUDC (Cornell)	2026
Louis Pasteur Prize for Best PhD Student Paper, AFE (UChicago)	2026
Dissertation Completion Fellowship, Harvard Griffin GSAS	2026
High Honors in Economics, Dartmouth College	2019
Magna Cum Laude, Dartmouth College	2019

Seminars & Conferences

CID Development Retreat (Harvard), AFE (UChicago), NEUDC (Cornell)	2026
CID Development Retreat (Harvard), ASREC Graduate Workshop (Chapman)	2024

Languages

Urdu (native), English (fluent), Hindi (conversational)

Citizenship

Pakistani